commitment that the Iraqi air force would not be allowed to fly over Jordanian airspace and that Iraqi army units would not be allowed to enter Jordan and threaten Israel.

The arguments for and against intervention were discussed daily at the cabinet meetings. The top echelons of the defense establishment, including the defense minister, urged intervention in the war. Most of the ministers around the table adopted a more passive stance and to the best of my recollection showed no real conviction in support of or against either position. Each day, at the end of the deliberations, no one demanded a vote, and the discussion ended with the clear understanding that we were not intervening and would revisit the issue at the following day's meeting. The prime minister found himself in the most difficult position—the defense minister and the top ranks of the IDF were against him, the rest of the ministers had not aligned in support of him, and he himself, as a former member and commander of the Lehi, was loath to exercise ongoing restraint in the face of attacks day after day; this position stood in sharp contrast to the worldview he had held since his youth. His decision against intervening was apparently a result of the axiom that was already being used in Israeli politics at that time, taken from the lyrics of a popular song: "What you see from here, you cannot see from there."

With hindsight, I have no doubt that the prime minister's decision not to intervene in the war was the correct one. The First Gulf War brought about at least two positive strategic results for Israel: the first was that the threat against Israel from the eastern front, which centered on Iraq, had disappeared. The second was that the First Gulf War, which was the first time that Arabs were pitted against Arabs, symbolized the end of the pan-Arab era in the Middle East.

And one more point in closing. In preparation for the publication of this book, I showed this chapter to Shlomo and asked his permission to include in it quotes from the unpublished paper he had written years earlier. Shlomo, in his great modesty, pointed out that the entire team that had worked with him also deserved mention and thanks. And so, I thank them here for their perseverance, their determination, and their extraordinary success in directing the gathering of intelligence and numerous prevention operations.